

WORLD BIBLE — EQUIVALENT ASHES

FULL CANON (DETAILED — NO SUMMARIES)

I. CORE LAW OF REALITY

Nothing happens without cost.

This is a physical law governing: - matter - energy - systems - human actions

Every change requires equivalent exchange.

Cost can be: - immediate - delayed - distributed - displaced

The central question of the world is NOT: "What is possible?"

It is:

Who pays?

II. CULTURAL EMBEDDING OF EXCHANGE

Equivalent Exchange is universally understood.

Children grow up hearing: - "Nothing is free" - "Someone always pays" - "Bad exchange"

This applies to: - work - relationships - morality - politics

People interpret events through cost distribution.

Example: A bridge collapse is not seen as failure of structure. It is seen as:

Someone made others pay the cost.

III. ALCHEMY (REAL FUNCTIONAL DETAIL)

Alchemy is a technical discipline.

It requires: - understanding of material structure - precise ratios - controlled execution

Most people know BASIC alchemy: - minor reinforcement - small conversions

Very few know ADVANCED alchemy: - structural systems - energy balancing

Practical Reality

A dock worker might: - patch a crate using crude alchemy

A trained alchemist might: - stabilize a building under stress

The difference is NOT access. It is precision.

Failure in Real Use

Common failures: - weak bonding - hidden stress points - uneven energy distribution

These failures often: - appear stable initially - fail later under pressure

This creates fear of:

delayed consequences

IV. DISTORTED ALCHEMY (REALISTIC VIEW)

Distortion is widely feared.

People describe it as: - "wrong results" - "things that shouldn't work, but do"

Example cases people know: - healed limb that bends incorrectly - revived body that "is not the same person"

Distortion is associated with: - arrogance - desperation - grief

V. HISTORY — FULL EXPANDED SOCIAL EXPERIENCE

ERA 1 — LIFE UNDER MAGIC RULE

Daily Life of a Slave:

- wakes before sunrise
- assigned labor without choice
- punishment for inefficiency
- no understanding of systems they build

A slave building a structure: - does not know why it works - only follows orders

Magic users: - rarely present physically - intervene only when needed

Their presence is enough to: - enforce obedience

ERA 2 — EARLY ALCHEMY DISCOVERY

First discoveries were accidental.

Example: A worker notices: - compressing material under heat changes structure

Repeated experiments: - inconsistent - dangerous

Knowledge spreads through: - whispers - observation

Not written records.

ERA 3 — PRE-REBELLION TENSION

Common people begin to: - understand materials - improve efficiency

Nobles respond with: - tighter control - harsher punishment

This creates: - resentment - hidden knowledge networks

ERA 4 — REBELLION (REAL PROCESS)

Rebellion is NOT sudden.

It develops as:

1. Small groups using alchemy to reduce labor
2. Sharing techniques secretly
3. Coordinated refusal of inefficient work
4. Local uprisings

Magic users respond inconsistently due to: - reduced numbers - instability

ERA 5 — RED HARROW (DETAILED EXPERIENCE)

People arrive at the valley knowing: - failure is inevitable for some

Workers are assigned positions like: - holding collapsing channels - reinforcing unstable gates

Each person understands: - their position will fail - timing matters more than survival

Key behavior: - no one leaves early - each waits until replacement arrives

This creates chain stability.

RESULT

Not success without cost.

But:

cost spread across many people instead of collapsing instantly

VI. LAW — REAL ENFORCEMENT

Law is NOT centralized.

It operates through:

1. Community judgment
 2. Reputation
 3. Escalation when harm spreads
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Illegal Acts (Practical Examples)

- reinforcing a structure poorly causing collapse
 - draining water affecting nearby communities
 - unsafe alchemy in shared spaces
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Social Consequences

More impactful than legal punishment:

- loss of trust
 - refusal of cooperation
 - isolation
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VII. TALASARA — FUNCTIONAL SOCIETY

Talasara is NOT unified.

It is a network of: - cities - trade hubs - regional powers

Authority weakens with distance.

Daily Life Differences

Urban: - structured work - access to materials

Rural: - self-reliance - improvised alchemy

VIII. ECONOMY — REAL MECHANICS

The economy is driven by: - material quality - energy efficiency

Example

Two builders:

Builder A: - uses low-HI material - builds quickly - structure fails later

Builder B: - uses better material - builds slower - structure lasts

Difference: - long-term cost vs short-term gain

IX. FACTIONS (FULL DETAIL)

1. COORDINATED EXCHANGE AUTHORITY (CEA)

Role

- manages large-scale projects
 - assigns labor and risk
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Daily Operation

- evaluates systems
 - determines weakest points
 - assigns workers accordingly
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Internal Logic

"If cost is not assigned deliberately, it will spread uncontrollably"

Criticism

Seen as: - cold - willing to sacrifice individuals

2. FREEHANDS NETWORK

Structure

- decentralized
 - informal
-

Daily Behavior

- sharing techniques freely
 - helping each other in work
-

Core Rule

"No one decides another person's cost"

Strength

- trust
 - adaptability
-

Weakness

- lack of coordination at scale
-

3. RED BALANCE MOVEMENT

Nature

Not openly organized.

Exists as: - ideology - scattered groups

Behavior

- pushes extreme solutions
 - accepts high cost outcomes
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Justification

"All change requires sacrifice"

Danger

Blurs line between: - necessary cost - unjustified harm

4. MEASURED SCHOLARS

Role

- study systems
- analyze outcomes

Daily Work

- evaluating incidents
- calculating solutions

Belief

"Correct calculation leads to correct outcomes"

Weakness

- ignores human factors

X. CORE CONFLICT SYSTEM

Every major conflict is based on:

Distribution of cost

Types of Conflict

1. Who pays?
2. When is cost acceptable?
3. Is efficiency more important than fairness?

XI. THEMES (FULLY INTEGRATED)

1. COSTLY GOOD DEEDS

A person does the right thing.

Immediate result: - loss - punishment

Long-term result: - others inspired - ripple effects

2. COLLECTIVE AMPLIFICATION

Groups achieve better outcomes because: - reduced waste - shared burden

NOT because of free energy.

Combined Effect

One person pays → many act → system changes

XII. PROTAGONIST

Member of Measured Scholars.

Starting Traits

- analytical
 - confident
 - emotionally detached
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Arc

1. trusts calculations
 2. sees failure of logic alone
 3. makes harmful "correct" decisions
 4. adapts worldview
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Core Conflict

Optimization vs humanity

XIII. DESIGN RULES

1. Every action has cost
 2. No clean morality
 3. No perfect solutions
 4. Cost must be visible or traceable
 5. Consequences must exist
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XIV. CANONICAL INCIDENTS AND MYTHS (FULL DETAIL)

These are NOT optional lore pieces. They define how society understands law, risk, and exchange.

1. THE DROWNING OF KARET BAY

Event

A trade consortium attempted to redirect a river to improve shipping efficiency.

They used large-scale alchemical flow manipulation.

Immediate Outcome

- river successfully redirected
 - port access improved
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Delayed Consequences

- freshwater supply collapsed
 - salinity increased
 - fisheries died
 - drinking water failed
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Human Impact

- starvation
 - disease
 - displacement
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Cultural Interpretation

"You took the river—and the people paid."

Legal Impact

- environmental harm classified as harm to others
 - large-scale alchemy requires scrutiny
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2. THE TWIN FORGING INCIDENT

Event

An alchemist attempted to distribute cost across two apprentices.

Method

- linked two humans into a shared exchange process
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Result

- structure succeeded
 - one died instantly
 - one lost cognitive function
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Cultural Interpretation

"People are not materials."

Legal Impact

- forced exchange became a major crime
- consent does not justify human use as resource

3. THE GLASS GARDEN

Event

A self-modifying alchemist enhanced their body repeatedly.

Early Phase

- improved efficiency
 - increased reputation
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Late Phase

- instability
 - loss of identity
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Final Outcome

- caused structural collapse during demonstration
 - civilian deaths
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Cultural Interpretation

"He traded himself—and others paid the rest."

Legal Impact

- self-harm becomes illegal if it risks others
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4. THE HOLLOW TOWER COLLAPSE

Event

A tower built with low-quality materials reinforced through alchemy.

Outcome

- passed inspection
 - stood for years
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Failure

- internal stress accumulated
 - catastrophic collapse
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Cultural Interpretation

"If it fails later, it was broken from the start."

Legal Impact

- delayed harm still punishable
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5. THE FIRST FALSE RESURRECTION

Event

A parent attempted to revive a child using alchemy.

Result

- body function restored
 - identity fragmented
 - violent behavior
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Outcome

- entity destroyed
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Cultural Interpretation

"That wasn't the child. It was the cost."

Legal Impact

- resurrection classified as illegal
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6. THE WEIGHING OF RED HARROW (MYTH + HISTORY)

Event Summary

A valley on the brink of collapse was saved through coordinated effort.

Reality

- multiple teams held failing points
 - individuals knowingly died
 - timing between groups prevented total collapse
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Core Truth

No miracle occurred.

Cost was: - real - fully paid - distributed across many

Cultural Meaning

"You don't carry it alone."

MODERN INTERPRETATIONS

State

"Order made it possible"

Workers

"People saved each other"

Radicals

"Sacrifice is necessary"

Scholars

"It was optimized exchange"

XV. META-RULE: HISTORY SHAPES LAW

All laws in Talasara are reactive.

They exist because: - someone already caused harm - society learned from failure

FINAL STATEMENT (UNCHANGED CORE)

This world is defined by:

A fair system with unfair outcomes.

Where: - cost cannot be avoided - only redistributed

And where:

Individuals pay first.

But through others, that cost can reshape the future.

END OF FULL CANON